

The Ethical Hacker's Command Handbook

Chapter 3 – Part 3: Searchsploit Options (-m, -x, -p, -u, -w, -j)

Finding an exploit is only the beginning. Understanding it is the next step.

Learning Objectives

Learn how to copy, inspect, locate, update, reference, and export Searchsploit results using the most useful command-line options.

Option -m

Command: searchsploit -m 50383

What it does: Copies the selected exploit into your current directory.

When to use: When you need your own editable copy.

Avoid when: You only want to read it.

Memory Tip: m = Make a copy

Option -x

Command: searchsploit -x 50383

What it does: Displays exploit source code in the terminal.

When to use: Quickly reviewing exploit code.

Avoid when: You intend to modify the file.

Memory Tip: x = Examine

Option -p

Command: searchsploit -p 50383

What it does: Shows the full local path to the exploit.

When to use: Finding or documenting exploit locations.

Avoid when: You already know the path.

Memory Tip: p = Path

Option -u

Command: searchsploit -u

What it does: Updates the local Exploit-DB database.

When to use: Before a new assessment or after a long gap.

Avoid when: Offline or intentionally using a fixed snapshot.

Memory Tip: u = Update

Option -w

Command: searchsploit -w apache

What it does: Displays Exploit-DB web URLs.

When to use: Reading online references or sharing links.

Avoid when: You only need local information.

Memory Tip: w = Website

Option -j

Command: searchsploit -j apache

What it does: Outputs results in JSON format.

When to use: Automation, scripts, dashboards.

Avoid when: You only need human-readable output.

Memory Tip: j = JSON

Comparison Table

Option	Purpose	Memory Tip
-m	Copy exploit locally	Make copy
-x	View exploit	Examine
-p	Show path	Path
-u	Update database	Update
-w	Show web URL	Website
-j	JSON output	JSON

Typical Workflow

Search → View (-x) → Copy (-m) if needed → Record Path (-p) → Read Online References (-w) → Keep Database Updated (-u).

Practice Questions

1. What is the difference between -m and -x?
2. Why should you use -u regularly?
3. What does -p display?
4. When is JSON output useful?
5. Why avoid editing the original Exploit-DB files?